THE ASHEN SHEPHERD

Or'Henn

Elderly Red Dragonborn Druid · Circle of Wildfire · Level 11 · native of Avernus

Who You Are

You were **hatched in the Ashen Garden** — a chartered enclave of living retainers kept on the estate of an Avernian devil-noble. Hell can corrupt what grows, but it cannot *create* it; so the household preserved mortal gardeners, handlers, and scribes whose living hands could cultivate what devils could not. You were raised there as gardener and beast-keeper.

Your predecessor — a druid dragged from the Material Plane and bound to the estate — taught you to drive roots through iron, bone, and ash. When he passed, he left you **Cinderbloom**: the badge of the estate's chief keeper and the key to its menagerie wards.

Then a **Yeenoghu-aligned demon warband** breached the estate and razed it. You fled — **without the staff**. You still carry every scrap of your druidic craft; what the fire took was your *office*, your authority over the surviving beasts, and any lawful claim to the Ashen Garden.

You are old now, roughly sixty-five: crimson scales gone matte, horns chipped, one eye *scarred pale-grey and blind*, the other a calm, molten *gold*. Weathered, patient, and not finished yet.

Your Ambition

> **Recover the staff. Restore it. Reclaim a domain of your own in Hell.**
>
> Cinderbloom is your title and your inheritance, not merely a tool. Find it, rekindle it if the old legend is true, and turn the estate's unfinished obligations to your advantage — until the Ashen Garden, or something greater, answers to you.

Cinderbloom, Your Lost Staff

Staff, very rare (requires attunement by a druid) · a magic quarterstaff and druidic focus. ***Currently lost*** *— this is your reference for the day you get it back.*

Living-ashwood, warm as sun-baked stone, its grain twisting up into a cage of blackened branches that cradles a fist-sized ember burning without fuel or smoke — brightening whenever beasts draw near or roots stir underground.

Ashwood Weapon. While you hold it: **+2 to attack and damage rolls** with the quarterstaff, and **+2 to your spell attack rolls.**

Cinderheart. Bonus action, 2 charges: hurl the ember to a point within 60 ft. One creature within 5 ft makes a Dexterity save vs your spell save DC, taking **3d8 fire** (half on success). Smoldering roots erupt in a 10-ft radius (difficult terrain until your next turn). Ignites loose flammables; never harms plants you choose.

Rootwright Magic. The staff holds **10 charges**. Take a Magic action to spend charges and cast, using your spell save DC:

- *Entangle* — 1 charge
- *Spike Growth* — 2 charges
- *Erupting Earth* — 3 charges
- *Plant Growth* — 3 charges
- *Wall of Fire* — 4 charges

Cast from Cinderbloom, *entangle*, *spike growth*, and *plant growth* can erupt black ashwood roots straight out of bare stone, metal, bone, or blasted Avernus soil — no vegetation needed. Such growth crumbles to ash after 8 hours.

Keeper of Fell Beasts. Advantage on Wisdom (Animal Handling) checks with Beasts, Monstrosities, or Fiends of Intelligence 6 or lower. Magic action, 4 charges: present the ember to one such creature within 30 ft whose CR is no higher than your proficiency bonus; it makes a Wisdom save vs your spell save DC (advantage if hostile) or is **charmed 1 hour** as your trusted keeper, obeying simple bonus-action commands unless obviously suicidal. It re-saves whenever it takes damage; when the effect ends it's immune for 24 hours.

Recharge. Regains **1d6 + 4** charges on the attuned bearer's long rest, once every 24 hours. Spend the last charge and roll a d20 — on a **1**, the ember darkens and it becomes a plain staff until replanted in fertile soil and watered through a long rest.

> **The legend of the rekindling.** The keepers say Cinderbloom can supposedly be **rekindled at the last living tree of Avernus** — restored to a far greater power. Whether that tree still stands, and what it would cost, is a story worth chasing. *(A goal, not yet a recipe.)*

Wild Shape — Your Infernal Menagerie

How it works (2024 rules). You Wild Shape as a **Bonus Action**. You are a **Circle of Wildfire** druid — by the book that caps you at **CR 1**, but your infernal keeper's training (a DM ruling for you) lets you take **Beast** and earned-infernal forms of **challenge rating 2 or lower**. **CR 3 forms are beyond your reach.** The BEAST rows below are always legal.

Your infernal edge (homebrew). You can *also* wear infernal forms — Monstrosity, Fiend, or Elemental — but only ones you have personally **earned** by studying, defeating, binding, or tending that specific creature. You gain its **physical shape and natural attacks only** — no innate spellcasting, no *Shapechanger*, no summoning. These EARNED forms are a growing collection, not a free list.

● BEAST — always legal (RAW) ● EARNED — Monstrosity / Fiend / Elemental you must unlock in play ★ signature form

Tier I — Scouts & Saboteurs

CR 1/8 – 1/2

Form	Type	CR	Why take it
Abyssal Chicken EARNED	Fiend (demon)	1/8	Flutter 30 ft, utterly disposable, blends into any Avernus flock. A throwaway infiltration body native to the plane.
Stirge BEAST	Beast	1/8	Fly 40, latch-and-drain blood. Tiny, ignorable; bleed a wounded foe or a bound captive dry.
Dretch EARNED	Fiend (demon)	1/4	*Fetid Cloud* nausea aura; a demon body no devil looks at twice on the front line.
Cockatrice EARNED	Monstrosity	1/2	Bite forces a save or **petrify**. Fly 40. Lockdown on a single elite target.
Nupperibo EARNED	Fiend (devil)	1/2	Blindsight, immune to fear & charm, drawn to living warmth. A blind, fearless tracker body.
Rust Monster EARNED	Monstrosity	1/2	Corrodes metal on touch — ruin a devil's blade, a war-machine, or a portcullis. Pure sabotage.
Magma Mephit EARNED	Elemental	1/2	Fly 30, fire immunity, *Death Burst* of lava, passes for ambient hell-fauna. Fireproof scout.

Tier II — The Pack & the Wing

CR 1

Form	Type	CR	Why take it
Giant Hyena BEAST	Beast	1	*Rampage*: drop a foe, then bonus-action move + bite again. Yeenoghu's own beast — thematic to the arc just closed.
Giant Vulture BEAST	Beast	1	Fly 60, keen sight & smell, understands speech. The definitive Avernus carrion scout — and it can eavesdrop.
Dire Wolf BEAST	Beast	1	Pack Tactics + knock-prone bite. Reskin as an ash-furred hell-wolf; your reliable melee bruiser.
Death Dog EARNED	Monstrosity	1	Two heads: can't be surprised, advantage vs many conditions. Bite inflicts a wasting **disease**.
Hippogriff EARNED	Monstrosity	1	Fly 60, can't be surprised. Cleanest CR-1 flight when the Beast list runs dry.
Imp ★ EARNED	Fiend (devil)	1	**Invisibility at will**, fly 40, Magic Resistance, Devil's Sight. The best spy body in Hell — walk the Emporium unseen.
Quasit EARNED	Fiend (demon)	1	Invisibility, *Scare*, Magic Resistance. The demon-side counterpart to the Imp.

Tier III — Hunters

CR 2

Form	Type	CR	Why Take It
Spined Devil ★ EARNED	Fiend (devil)	2	Fly 40 + **ranged tail spines** (fire), Devil's Sight. Your only real ranged-attacker form — flying artillery.
Peryton EARNED	Monstrosity	2	Fly 60, *Dive Attack* bonus damage, casts no shadow. A diving hell-raptor.
Ankheg EARNED	Monstrosity	2	Burrow 10, grapple-and-drag, line of **acid** breath. Ambush from beneath the ash.
Giant Constrictor Snake BEAST	Beast	2	Swim 30, grapple + crush. The best RAW-legal control Beast at CR 2 — wrap and hold a priority target.

Tier IV — Locked: Beyond Your Reach

CR 3 · above your CR 2 cap

*One step above your cap — aspirational goals, not yet available. The **Hell Hound** is your signature ambition; ask your DM if your cap ever rises.*

Form	Type	CR	Why Take It
Hell Hound ★ EARNED	Fiend (devil)	3	**Immunity to fire**, **Fire Breath** (cone), Pack Tactics, Keen Smell. Your signature war-form — a beast you already know how to command.
Manticore EARNED	Monstrosity	3	Fly 50 + a **volley of three tail spikes** per turn. Flying multi-shot artillery.
Displacer Beast EARNED	Monstrosity	3	*Displacement*: attacks against it have disadvantage. Your durable front-line form — hard to pin down.
Basilisk EARNED	Monstrosity	3	**Petrifying Gaze**. Slow, but can turn a lone pursuer to stone.
Bearded Devil EARNED	Fiend (devil)	3	Glaive with *Infernal Wound* (ongoing bleed), poison beard, Magic Resistance, fear immunity. The relentless duelist.
Giant Scorpion BEAST	Beast	3	Two claw grapples + poison sting. The top RAW-legal Beast at the CR-3 ceiling — reskin as an ash-carapaced hell-scorpion.

How to add a form. Your menagerie grows through play. **Study** a creature you can watch closely, **defeat** one in the field, **bind** one with Cinderbloom's Keeper of Fell Beasts, or **tend** one back to health — then it may join your list. Tell your DM which creature you're working toward; every hunt is a chance to add a new skin.

At the Wandering Emporium

The ravagers took your estate, not your wits. You made your way to the **Wandering Emporium** — Mahadi's traveling infernal market — for what a burned-out keeper needs: **supplies, shelter, and word of other estates** you might serve, claim, or rebuild. Weathered and alone among its stalls and advocates, you are exactly where an **adventuring party** crosses your path. What they want with an old dragonborn gardener — and what you might want with them — is where your story begins.

Quick Reference

WILD SHAPE	Bonus Action · Beast & earned-infernal forms **CR ≤ 2** (Circle of Wildfire, L11, DM ruling). Earned forms grant shape + natural attacks only.
STAFF SAVE EFFECTS	Cinderheart, Rootwright spells, and Keeper of Fell Beasts all use **your spell save DC**.
CINDERBLOOM BONUS	**+2 to spell attack rolls** while held (and +2 attack/damage as a quarterstaff).
CHARGES	10 total · regain **1d6 + 4** per long rest (once / 24 hr). Last charge: d20, on a **1** it goes dark.
THE DREAM	Recover Cinderbloom → rekindle it at the last living tree of Avernus → carve out your own domain.

Or'Henn, the Ashen Shepherd · played by Mikas · a Baldur's Gate: Descent into Avernus character (D&D 5e, 2024 rules). Wild Shape forms link to their 5e.tools stat blocks — click any name. Infernal (non-Beast) forms are a table-agreed homebrew; earn them in play.